

Popping my Apple cherry

As unbelievable as it may sound, I haven't spent a significant amount of time on an iPhone. Ever. Yes, until recently I was an iVirgin. Sure, I've dipped my err stick in the Apple ecosystem a few times before – an iMac for a while in 2012, and one of the very first iPads as my only computing device on a rather long offsite assignment back in 2013 – but never the iPhone specifically. My interaction with every new iteration of the homogeneous device was limited to the few minutes of “ohh so this is what the gold iPhone 5 looks like?” followed by the usual “Meh”.

Over the last couple of months however, I've had the pleasure of using the 128GB iPhone 6S Plus. Having used it as my primary mobile communications device, I've had the chance to come to some really solid conclusions not only from the tech standpoint, but also from the socio-cultural perspective. As you might imagine carrying around a ₹92,000 phone has peculiar effects on how you are perceived by people. I'll keep this bit reserved for another rant and for now just focus on the technology aspect.

So what's my verdict about the phone? It's an absolutely brilliant device with an utterly ridiculous, almost castrated UI. Most people who come to this conclusion make the mistake of saying it's the operating system that is bad. This is not necessarily accurate because iOS, for whatever its interface handicaps may be, plays quite well with the underlying hardware; as it evident from its battery life and smooth operation. It's the uppermost layer that I have a problem with.

What's so wrong with iOS on the usability front? Where do I begin!

Apple seems to have a dogged desire to keep things simple. That's not such a bad goal to aspire to, but when your penchant for simplicity crosses over into downright dumbing down of things, it's something to worry about. Take the home button for instance. I'm sorry but making me go tick-tick on it twice to bring up multitasking just seems moronic. This brings me to another issue – what's with not having a back button? People defending this design philosophy will say that apps are coded to have their own contextual back buttons.

Yes they do. But hardly ever in the same place! Sometimes a close button appears at the top left (for eg while playing a video in the Facebook app) and sometimes a “Done” appears on the top right. Why should these buttons be placed at the top? iPhones certainly aren't getting any smaller (oh wait they are!). If sometime in the future Apple decides to have a back “feature” I'm pretty sure they're going to find a convoluted way of implementing it, all in an effort to adamantly stick to their precious solitary home button. Who knows, maybe they'll make you go tick tick tick thrice on the damn thing.

I think the reason Apple comes up with these absurd workarounds is because they have a tendency of making proclamations that'll come back to bite them later. Remember how Apple stubbornly refused to have a two button mouse for the longest time? Tell me, is “control clicking” to bring up contextual menus seriously more intuitive than having a right click right there on one single input device? The home button seems to be one of those things where they've dug their heels deep.

Since the time I've been using the phone I've been quite vocal about reporting my experiences on social media. On one such post, I had a fanboy come up and declare “the only people who hate Apple are those who hate simplicity and reliability.” Well, butter knives are simple and reliable. But if someone were to give me a Victorinox and it just happens to have a butter knife as one of pull out blades, I wouldn't complain. That's exactly what Android feels like to me – an OS that delivers your basics along with complex tools for those who want them.

On the reliability bit too I'm not entirely convinced. You know that thing they say about how Apple products “just work”. Well they do... except when they don't. On the very first run the iPhone gave me trouble by going into this get-install loop while downloading apps (a known issue: <http://dgit.in/ApplAppSt>). How'd I fix it? A restart of course! Not very different from the “when all else fails, restart” model we follow for other tech products right?

Don't even get me started on that mess of an application they call iTunes (at least on



Siddharth Parwatay
Managing Editor

siddharth.parwatay@digit.in

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Windows). The whole process of transferring music onto the phone is so daunting, I've been procrastinating more than my usual share. But I'll leave that for another rant for it's now time to wind up.

The phone does have a few things going for it though. The hardware obviously (brilliant camera for instance), but on the software front too I like that the apps are better built. Perhaps the result of stricter quality standards imposed by the App Store.

Either ways, there you have it – a blow by blow account of an iVirgin's deflowering. You know where to send your hate mail. But remember to be gentle, it's my first time :-)

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